
CAFÉ DE LA LUNA
RESEARCH SERIES
0 – 10
I work to explore
Code Bites
Programming, Roads and Other Unintended Consequences
Same roads.
Different cities.
Same questions.
Better stories.
Some bugs turn into good stories.
Code.
Roads.
People.
Dogs.
Unexpected turns.
Same life.
EVGENIY TYURKIN
18 September 2026
CAFÉ DE LA LUNA
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Evgeniy Tyurkin

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1. Arrival

On March 2, 2018, I flew from Toronto to India.

Two weeks in Hyderabad lay ahead of me. Oracle had sent me there to observe a local team and figure out why it was considered inefficient.

But the main problem started long before the work did.

I smoked.

Once I cleared security in Toronto, there was nowhere to smoke. Then came the overnight flight to London, several hours at Heathrow, and another long flight to Hyderabad.

At first, all I wanted was a cigarette. Then the wanting stopped being a thought and became part of my body.

By the time we landed, I was already starting to shake a little.

Not from excitement. Not from India.

From nicotine.

A driver met me at the airport. We got into the car and pulled away. Outside the window was a country I had never seen before: different air, different light, a different city.

At that moment, only one question mattered.

“Can I smoke?”

The driver answered calmly.

“Of course. Just open the window.”

I opened the window and lit a cigarette.

I had smoked many cigarettes before that one. I would smoke many after it. But I still remember that cigarette.

It was the best cigarette of my life.

I suppose that was where India began for me. Not with the fort, not with the museum, not with curry, and not with Oracle.

With an open car window early in the morning in Hyderabad.

I took a drag. Everything was fine again.

Now I could look around.

2. Consultant

I stayed at the Red Fox Hotel. The Oracle office was about a ten-minute walk away. For me, that is almost the perfect distance: no driver, no taxi. You step outside and walk. By the time you get there, you are awake and have had a chance to look around.

The technical director of the Indian office described the problem simply:

the team isn't working efficiently.

I had come in as a consultant. My job was to watch how people actually worked, understand

what was happening, and then say what should be done about it.

I did not like the word “inefficient.” It explains nothing.

So for the first few days, I changed almost nothing. I worked alongside the team and watched. Who talked to whom. Who people went to with questions. Where the pauses appeared. What happened when something went wrong.

Systems rarely explain themselves in words.

They explain themselves through behavior.

The first useful clue appeared during an ordinary stand-up.

My first real experience with Scrum had been years earlier in Saint Petersburg, at StarSoft. Our Scrum Master was Zhenya Terzey. I had read the books, of course, but I understood the meaning of the process through daily practice, not from a book.

Later, at Oracle, they decided to put an extra responsibility on me that I was not particularly eager to take on. I said that, in that case, some formal Scrum training would be a good idea. Mike supported it, Oracle paid for the course, and I became a certified Scrum Master.

The extra responsibility stayed, but at least I got paid for it in knowledge.

A stand-up is not for the boss. It is a quick check of the team's state: who is doing what, what has changed, and, most importantly, whether there are any obstacles.

If an obstacle needs a separate discussion, you set it aside. After the stand-up, the people who actually need that conversation stay behind.

There were about eight people on the team.

The director came to the first stand-up.

The first person started talking. The director asked a question. A discussion began. Then came another question, details, explanations. Everyone else stood there.

Then it was the second person's turn, and the same thing happened again.

The meeting took about thirty minutes.

People were not talking to one another. They were reporting upward. One person to the director, then the second person to the director, then the third. Everyone else waited for their turn.

It had become a series of small meetings with one manager and a mandatory audience standing around him.

And another purpose of the stand-up had disappeared: context.

If I am simply waiting for my turn to report, I have almost no reason to listen to anyone else.

I did not need to change the people, the director, or Scrum.

Just one connection.

3. The Ball

The next day, there was a small rubber ball lying on the table.

I cannot honestly say that I invented the idea. Most likely, it simply surfaced. Possibly from StarSoft. Some things, after enough good practice, stop being rules you remember and become reflexes.

I picked up the ball.

“Today we’re going to play.”

The rule was simple. While you are holding the hot potato, you talk: what happened yesterday, what you are doing today, whether anything is blocking you. When you are done, throw

it to anyone you want. Not the next person in the circle, not necessarily the person beside you, and definitely not the boss.

The ball started moving.

The first person gave his update and threw it. The next person caught it, spoke briefly, and threw it again.

Very quickly, the conversation changed direction. People stopped automatically looking at the director. Nobody knew who would get the ball next, so they had to listen to one another.

The short updates began to add up to a shared picture. Who was working on what. What was moving. Where a dependency

had appeared. What might affect your own work.

Not a report.

Context.

Then somebody started going deeper into the details. The ball stayed in his hands and the story got longer.

The potato was hot.

Then again, there are yogis.

“Parking lot.”

The ball moved on.

At one point, the director asked a question.

“Parking lot.”

And the ball moved on again.

The team itself probably could not have stopped its own director quite so casually.

I could.

That was what I had been invited there to do.

After the stand-up, I spoke with the director. Not “you are interfering,” and not “you are the problem.” I simply explained that his presence changed the process itself. People started taking into account not only the work of the team, but also the person standing above them in the hierarchy.

Yesterday, the stand-up had taken about thirty minutes.

Today, about two.

Same people. Same tasks.

Only the pattern of interaction had changed.

The next day, the director did not come to the stand-up.

The ball did.

Then another day.

And another.

At first, people simply followed the rule. Then a rhythm appeared.

And once a rhythm exists, you hear immediately when it breaks.

Someone starts going into details, holds onto the ball too

long, and the whole team can feel it: there is something here.

At first, I was the one who said:

“Parking lot.”

Then one day I did not get the chance.

Someone on the team said it before I could.

“Parking lot.”

That was when the experiment ended.

The game belonged to them.

Only many years later did I understand that I had done one more thing.

First, I removed the director from the process. Not because he

necessarily interfered by speaking. Even if he had simply stood there and watched in silence, he would still have been the director. His presence alone changed the team's behavior — and therefore changed what I was able to observe.

Then I introduced the game and held it together for a while myself. But if I had kept being the first person to say "Parking lot," the game would gradually have become mine. I would merely have replaced one center with another.

That is why the moment when the team said it before I could mattered more than I understood at the time.

I got the game running.

Then I stepped out of it.

I did not have a word for that yet. Much later, one appeared: **Observer**.

Do not lead a working system by the hand. Show a direction, remove the interference, let it begin moving on its own, and step in only when it is clearly stuck or heading the wrong way.

Jokes appeared. People threw the ball unexpectedly. Someone would get caught not listening. Sometimes the ball came to me. I had work of my own, too.

Catch it. Say your piece. Throw it.

After a while, I stopped looking at the clock. It no longer mattered whether the stand-up took two minutes or three. It was doing what it was supposed to do again.

A plant needs soil, sun, and rain.

You do not have to pull it upward by the stem.

4. On Foot

March 10 was a Saturday.

That morning I left the Red Fox. The first photos from the day are timestamped 8:37 and 8:47.

By then I had learned not to underestimate the local sun. I covered my arms, pulled up a hood, took water and my phone, and started walking.

I like walking through unfamiliar cities. A car moves you from one point to another. On foot, the world appears between the points.

Streets, houses, people, dogs, small temples, construction sites.

At one point I saw a woman carrying bricks on her head. The image stayed with me. Behind shop counters, I had mostly seen men. Here, a woman was carrying bricks.

Later I asked the guys at the office about it. They gave me some explanation about women not being able, or not being expected, to work in what they called the public sector.

I never quite understood what they meant.

But I remembered the contrast.

I had Archery Supplies India marked on the map.

At around eleven, I reached the spot where the map said it should be and stopped.

There was no store.

There was an address. There was a building. There were people.

There was no store.

No sign. No display window. No bows.

I walked around the building.

Then again.

Then a third time.

The map continued to insist that I had arrived.

A man was sitting nearby.

“Do you know where the archery store is?”

He shrugged and spread his hands.

I tried again.

The same gesture: I don’t understand.

So I stopped using English.

I raised my left arm and drew an imaginary bowstring with my right.

He lit up immediately.

We had found a language.

He shouted something up toward the building. A man appeared on the second floor, and after a while a door opened.

The store existed after all.

5. The Archer and the Road

The owner spoke fluent English.

“I want native Indian bow. Do you have any?”

He said he did, but I probably would not like it, and suggested I look at Olympic bows instead.

I thanked him.

“I can buy those at home.”

He sighed.

“All right. Come on. I’ll show you.”

He showed me a bow.

I looked at it.

It looked roughly as if someone had taken two skis and bolted them to a riser.

“No. That’s not it.”

I explained that I was looking for historical Indian bows, or faithful replicas.

“You have such an enormous history of archery.”

He sighed.

He said that the tradition had mostly been lost, and what he had just shown me was about all that was available now.

We talked for almost two hours. He was an archer himself, and an instructor.

There were small figurines of archers in the shop. I asked what they were. He said they were made for children as small prizes at competitions.

I wanted one.

“Can I buy one?”

No. They were not for sale.

Then he picked one up and handed it to me.

A gift.

I offered to pay.

He refused.

I had gone looking for a historical Indian bow. He could not give me one of those.

But he could give me a little Indian archer.

Before I left, he refilled my water bottle.

It was about one in the afternoon.

I stepped outside, looked at the map, and decided to take a different way back.

The same road would have been boring.

The return route took me through different streets. Fewer people, more walls, construction sites, cows, small temples.

The navigation worked for a while, then told me to turn right.

I looked to the right.

There was a wall.

White. Long. Real.

On the map, there was a road.

In reality, there was not.

I had to go around.

The navigation calmly recalculated as if nothing had happened.

It got hotter. GPS was eating the battery. My water was running low.

When the battery got very low, I turned navigation off. I remembered the general direction. I also decided to stop taking pictures. I wanted to preserve whatever charge was left.

Then the water ran out.

My mouth went dry. My legs and knees hurt.

By then, the whole task had narrowed to one thing:

make it back.

I could not slow down too much. Once an exhausted body gets the message that it can relax, getting it moving again becomes much harder.

I could ease the pace a little.

I could not stop.

On one street, there was a man selling water.

The water was right there. I could buy it and drink it.

I wanted to.

Very much.

But before the trip, we had been specifically warned not to buy water or drinks from street vendors. We had been told that, on an earlier trip, several people had ended up in hospital after doing so.

I walked past.

Then more road.

Heat. Dry mouth. Fatigue.

Keep moving.

After a while, I saw a red Coca-Cola sign ahead.

A café.

A perfectly ordinary café.

Clean water.

Familiar food.

A chair.

I went in, asked for water with ice, and ordered a double cheeseburger.

I sat there, drank, ate, and looked out the window.

Only then did my body get permission to stop.

Afterward, I went back outside.

The phone was still alive.

Barely.

I left it alone.

Then, finally, I saw the familiar hotel complex ahead.

Red Fox.

The destination was in sight.

I took out the phone.

One percent.

I did not take the last photo because the view was beautiful.

I just wanted to record the moment.

Made it.

3:07 p.m.

The shutter clicked.

The phone went dark.

Back in the room, I plugged the phone in.

Finally, I could stop too.

After a while, I opened my banking app.

Amazon.

More Amazon.

More.

From the amounts and descriptions, it looked as though someone had decided to buy about a hundred Kindle books.

I messaged my wife.

“Did you happen to buy books on Amazon?”

“No. Why? I don’t even have a Kindle.”

Now I knew what to do: block the card and dispute the transactions.

One problem remained.

I was in India.

The bank was in Canada.

And then an old program surfaced from my Saint Petersburg past.

WebCallDirect.

There was still about ten dollars sitting in the account.

Hello, EvaPhone.

I got through to the bank. They blocked the card, and the money was later refunded.

I had another card with me.

That morning, I had left the hotel simply to see the city and find an archery shop.

I came back with a little archer, aching legs, an almost-dead phone, and a hundred books I had never bought.

A normal Saturday.

6. What Remained

On another day, I went to the Salar Jung Museum.

And there I finally found what I had been looking for.

Real artifacts.

Historical bows.

Arrows.

Figures of archers.

And an entire array of thumb rings dating from the sixteenth through the nineteenth centuries.

One of the rings was associated with Shah Jahan.

I walked along the display cases and took photographs.

What I had not found in the shop was here, behind glass.

I got what I wanted.

I just could not take it home.

I came back to Canada with the little archer figurine and the photographs.

Everything else stayed there.

I also took a separate trip by taxi: Golconda Fort and the zoo. This time, I could simply ride, get out, look around, and get back in.

By the end of the second week, I was craving food that tasted different.

One evening, I opened the hotel menu and saw:

Pasta Carbonara.

Finally.

I ordered it.

It arrived.

I tasted it.

Curry.

Of course.

7. The Last Friday

The last working day.

The team was still working in the same rhythm. The ball had a life of its own now.

The director had scheduled a farewell meeting for the evening.

At lunch, I decided to visit the market near the hotel for the first time.

As a white foreigner, I stood out immediately. Someone grabbed my arm, someone tried to show me something, someone tried to sell me something.

One shawl seller did none of that.

He simply invited me to talk.

We sat and talked. He told stories and asked me questions. Then he told me about the Himalayas and about a shawl that had kept him warm there at minus forty.

I laughed.

“I know what minus forty feels like. I was born and raised in Siberia.”

I bought the shawl anyway.

For my mother.

Then I looked at the time.

I was already cutting it close for the farewell meeting.

On the way back to the office, I also managed to stop at a jewelry store and buy my mother some pearls. She loves pearls.

A shawl.

Pearls.

Then I rushed back to the office.

The team had already gathered.

I could have summarized the visit, explained what had changed, and given recommendations.

Instead, I told them about Sasha.

When she came to me, she would not let me touch her.

She bit.

Not out of spite.

She had already had three owners before me.

I could have decided she was a bad dog and tried to stop the biting.

Instead, I wanted to understand why she bit.

I found my way to her step by step. What frightened her. When I could come closer. When it was better to back off.

Gradually, she let me touch her.

Then she began to trust me.

I told the team:

“Code works the same way. If you don’t love what you’re doing, the code will bite.”

You can refactor it later. But if you refactor without understanding the system and caring about it, you just get work for work’s sake.

That was where I stopped.

8. Home

The next day, I flew home.

At security in Hyderabad, there was a problem.

My Zippo.

The one with the wolves.

To the security officer, it was just a lighter.

To me, those wolves were Jay and Sasha.

They told me I could not take it through.

I explained that I had flown into India with it from Toronto through London.

It did not help.

I explained that it mattered to me as a keepsake.

It did not help.

I asked for a supervisor.

That did not help either.

There was a rule.

No lighter.

“Fine. Take the insert. Give me the case. The case itself isn’t dangerous, is it?”

That worked.

They kept the insert.

The Zippo case came home with me.

I bought a replacement insert in Toronto later.

After that, I went into the airport smoking room.

There was an electric lighter built into the wall: a small opening, a heating element inside, a button beside it.

Press.

Wait.

Light your cigarette.

At the beginning of the trip, the driver had let me light up in his car.

Now India had built fire into the wall.

I could go home.

The route back was the same: London, then Toronto.

I got home.

And almost immediately went out for a walk with Jay and Sasha.

Afterword

I brought a little archer figurine and a lot of photographs back from India.

Later, I posted those photographs of historical bows, arrows, and thumb rings in the ATARN Facebook group, a community of traditional archery researchers.

People there were grateful for them.

A trace can be passed on.

A scent cannot.

Back then, I still did not have a name for it:

Programming by Feel.